

**AUSTRALIAN JUNIOR CHESS PROBLEM-SOLVING CHAMPIONSHIP
SYDNEY, 14 January 2014**

Report V3 by Nigel Nettheim
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Solving in progress (Photo: Richard Gastineau-Hills).

1. This was the eighth year of the problem-solving event, following Canberra 2007, Sydney 2008, Adelaide 2009, Hobart 2010, Melbourne 2011, Melbourne 2012 and the Gold Coast 2013. Reports on earlier events can be seen via <http://OzProblems.com> under Links.
2. A single paper was set for all ages, trophies then being awarded for the U18 and U12 open and girls, cash prizes for the open and girls groups U18, U16, U14, U12, U10 and U8, and a number of encouragement awards of chess books kindly donated by Gary Lane. The list of prize-winners is available on the Championship web site at <http://www.ajcc.org.au/prize-list> . The numbers of solvers are shown in Table 1. The total number of solvers was 85, the largest number for this event so far.
3. Each solver was provided with a board and men.
4. The time taken was noted when each question sheet was handed in, to be used if necessary to break ties. Few competitors left particularly early, most staying for the whole two hours.

5. The question sheets and the solutions are included at the end of this file. I also have spare hard-copies that may be requested.

6. My article entitled “A Quick Introduction to Chess Problems and End-game Studies”, which I had originally prepared for the 2007 Championship, was made available on the present Championship’s web site. The article is of some value in making sure that competitors know in advance what problems and studies are, and that they have been exposed to a suitable introduction to them, with examples. Before solving started I also explained what “Mate in 2 moves” means, because not all entrants may have been familiar with the term.

7. The format of the question sheet continues to work well: a single A3 sheet folded over to take up A4 size, with only the instructions on the front page so that the sheet could be placed unopened on the tables in advance.

8. During the solving period, Richard Gastineau-Hills kindly joined me in invigilating and answering questions from the solvers, while Arthur Huynh assisted by collecting and timing completed papers. As was to be expected, most questions were asked by the younger solvers, mainly concerning the meaning of self-mate (problem 7) and of the key (question 6) (both discussed below).

9. Marking was carried out by myself, with further checking by Ian Rogers in cases where the results were close. No ties resulted for the main prizes, so the solving times did not need to be used.

10. The markers’ job is assumed to be finished when the total marks have been reported in each of the 12 birth-year/gender sections. The tournament organizers then apply a method of determining prizes according to their desired scheme. The markers have a role to play in breaking any ties and in recommending any special awards.

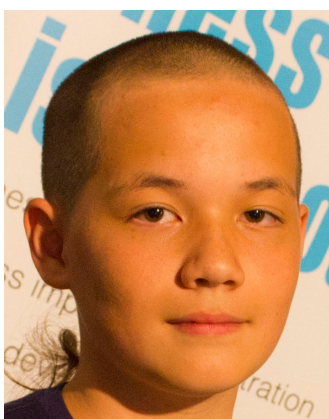
11. Very many thanks indeed are offered to Geoff Foster for once again carrying out the time-consuming expert job of selecting the direct-mate tasks and preparing the papers and solutions for printing. I proposed the studies and solved the tasks.

12. The general impression from their comments was that competitors enjoyed the event. The administrators also seemed very satisfied with it. It has been reported that parents like the “examination” atmosphere of the event, making it seem somewhat similar to a school exam and thus suggesting that chess is not just a matter of their children playing games – an unforeseen favourable effect. Gary Lane has made the point that most juniors do not continue playing chess seriously after their school days, and problem-solving has a value in providing a chess activity that they can more easily carry with them into the future.

13. The influence of coaches in promoting problem-solving was again noticeable, and is to be encouraged. Coaches could explain that under-promotion and stalemate arise more often in problems and studies than in chess games. However, this year’s open winner, Linus Cooper, confessed that he seldom solves problems during the year, although he has a few books on the subject. The runner-up, Lalit Prasad, had worked through the 2013 paper and concluded – correctly – that it was best to look for “weird” moves rather than ones that come naturally to a player. The composition of problems or studies has occasionally been

attempted by juniors, and is a long-term goal of the solving activity.

14. As always, our policy has been not to release individual results. The reasons for this include the following: (i) No disparagement was ever intended towards those scoring low marks, especially as some may never have seen a formal problem or endgame study before. (ii) Requests for revision might lead to prolonged correspondence for which there simply isn't time, and the marking has already been done with all care (see paragraph 9). (iii) In cases where it was already clear that prizes would not be affected, less attention might be given to the awarding of partial credit or the resolving of small differences, as a purely practical matter. (iv) The marks scored have meaning only in relation to the particular tasks set and their difficulty, so that comparisons from year to year, or to school-work exams, would not be valid. We nevertheless give the top mark (please do not request others): Linus Cooper, under 14, solved 14 straight tasks before time had expired, thus scoring 140/150.



Linus Cooper, the 2014 Australian Junior Chess Problem-Solving Champion
(under-18 open) (Photo: Sydney Academy of Chess)

15. A summary of the average marks awarded in each section is given in Table 2. Averaged over all ages, boys did better than girls this year, though only by a small margin in the older age-groups. When setting the tasks it is desired that the marks be not too low, so that solvers get some satisfaction from their efforts, and that was achieved quite well. On the other hand, some difficult tasks are needed in an attempt to separate the best solvers. The top few solvers were the only ones to do well in the last three tasks, so that function was served too. The progression of difficulty through the three pages of questions was about as expected (the statistics are not shown here) except that the proof game (No. 9) was very much better solved than had been expected. Thus a paper with a generally similar level of difficulty seems indicated for next year.

16. Here are some brief comments on each of the fifteen tasks:

- 1) Each year we attempt to provide one or more “gifts”, so that everyone gets some satisfaction, bearing in mind that some solvers are very young; this one suited the purpose well.
- 2) This was intended as a near-gift and most solved it.
- 3) Once again intended as a gift.
- 4) This is now a real chess-problem. A number of near-misses (1.Qd5, 1.Qe5, 1.Qf4, 1.Qb7) were given a little partial credit; quite a few young solvers got it right.
- 5) Some missed the long retreat 2.B(a6)-f1. Partial credit of 2/10 was given for a shorter retreat by the Bishop.
- 6) The two-part quiz format allowed us to ask for a little more than just the key-move. This

was again well-solved, so scores for tasks 1-6 were high, as intended. During the session a few asked for the meaning of “key”, a term which should be made clearer in future.

7) This self-mate was included as an experiment, attempting to make the set of questions as varied as could be managed. Despite the careful wording, it turned out to be not well grasped.

8) An effective study, starting with two pawn-sacrifices and ending with mate by the least-likely pawn. An attempt to apply triangulation (1.Ke3 Kg4 2.Ke4 Kh4? 3.Kf3) was quite reasonable, although 2...h4! is available.

9) The proof game turned out to be very much easier than expected.

10) Many of the older competitors solved this. The tries (1.Nd2, 1.Na5) quite often caught them, though, and received partial credit. 1.Qxe6 was also tempting.

11) Again quite a few of the older competitors solved this, but not many younger ones, as was to be expected.

12) A quite difficult mate in 2, the key-move being a three-way sacrifice.

13) The last three tasks, and especially the last two, were intended to be hard enough to separate the top solvers. The choice between 1.Rhc5 and 1.Rcc5 was difficult, one solver justifiably writing “Very tricky”. Partial credit of 3/10 was given for the wrong choice.

14) A difficult study, the idea of bringing about a stalemate being very well hidden. After 1.Bg5+ most solvers moved the Black King to f3, attempting to assist the Pg3, but the Black King turned out to be needed on the other side of the board. Only one solver, the eventual winner, found the complete solution, so this task served its purpose well.

15) The solution to the last task was particularly hard for players to find, being a waiting-move into the corner of the board. Again only one solver was successful.

Best wishes for the future!

Nigel Nettheim, 29 January 2014.

Appendix. How a junior problem-solving event may be run

The following suggestions are included for the possible reference of anyone taking on this job in the future.

How the tasks may be selected:

General:

1. Secrecy: keep this work in strict isolation until the moment when solving begins for, if the selections were revealed beforehand, the competition would immediately collapse.
2. Types of task: direct-mates (mate in 2 moves, or 3 moves etc.) and endgame studies are the most likely ones. It may be too hard to explain other types succinctly on the paper. But whimsical questions could occasionally be used (e.g. White mates on his 5th move under such-and-such conditions: give the game score; or simple retro-analysis tasks).
3. Ease of marking: this should be taken into account when selecting, for it can make the difference between a task being practicable for the event or not.
4. Ease of writing out solutions: there should not be too many moves in the solution to be written down by the solvers (and read by the markers).
5. Soundness: use computer checking whenever available, although it's good to have an occasional computer-proof task.
6. High quality and attractiveness: this is important in showing the artistic side of problems, leading to an increased interest in them. (A close familiarity with the enormous world of chess problems and studies is needed to judge quality and attractiveness.)
7. Clutter: avoid too many cluttered positions, because they take time for the solvers to set up and verify during solving, and may lead to setting-up errors.
8. Obscurity: tasks not too likely to have been already seen by solvers are preferred, at least for tasks aimed at expert solvers, where the most famous composers may be best avoided. A scheme is needed to make sure that tasks that were used in previous Australian Junior solving events are not used again.
9. A wide variety of difficulty levels is wanted – something for everyone, including a gift or two for complete novices, especially very young ones down to age 6 or younger, and one or two very difficult tasks attempting to separate the experts. When working on arranging the paper one may assign a mark out of 10 for the estimated difficulty of proposed tasks, to help control the range of difficulty levels. Keep in mind possibilities of giving partial credit.
10. The selector(s) should solve each proposed task themselves, to understand the solver's point of view rather than only the composer's point of view and to anticipate possible unintended and unwanted features.
11. Hints or supporting information can be added (e.g. K+N+B v K wins in general).
12. Quiz questions can be asked. For instance: The key (White's first move) is 1.Nf6 or 1.Nb6. A. Which one? B. What move would Black make after the other one?
13. It is good to convey something instructive to the solvers when the opportunity arises (via quiz questions or hints or in the solutions to be provided) so that their understanding may improve from year to year.
14. Large databases of high-quality tasks are useful, because they contain so many tasks that it is fairly easy to avoid ones that competitors are likely to have seen.

Considerations on particular types of task:

Studies:

- S1. Clarity: selecting studies with few side-lines or alternatives that need to be dealt with will make marking easier.
- S2. Avoid assuming a knowledge of endgame theory other than the simplest, for the younger solvers will not know it. Otherwise state that theory in a note.
- S3. Avoid any contentiousness that could lead to counter-claims or complaints.
- S4. A variety of themes and styles is best, including perhaps a balance of wins and draws.
- S5. Abbreviated versions of published studies can be very useful in satisfying some of the above desiderata. That includes gifts and near-gifts (useful to try to give all solvers a sense of satisfaction) which are hard to find in publications otherwise. Many studies seem to have been composed from a mid-way starting position that has a very clear solution requiring no complex analysis, and have then been extended at the beginning to gain length and also to become more challenging to study connoisseurs; for our purposes the clear mid-way starting point is often preferable, thus with abbreviation by the removal of its first few moves.
- S6. Computers are often fallible in solving studies, so there is no substitute for careful human checking. Of course humans are fallible too, so here we are faced with the fact that chess is a difficult game. In some cases, however, computers are infallible: a database exists which evaluates all positions with six or fewer men (<http://www.shredderchess.com/>).

Direct mates:

- D1. Problems with many tries may or may not be suitable. They allow luck to play a larger role (via the order in which the solver decides to explore the tries), for in competitive speed-solving (rather than calmer appreciative solving) one does not need to explore all the tries. Tries may be more acceptable here if they all draw themselves to the solver's attention, for instance by being made with the same piece or to the same square. They may also be included in the form of quiz questions.
- D2. Set play, on the other hand, need not be avoided even though it might not be noticed when solving under a time limit. For it does not increase the role of luck; and it seems not disadvantageous, because solvers can appreciate the full solution later from the answer sheet.
- D3. A variety of themes or types is good (e.g. not all waiting-move problems; not all involving under-promotion).

Other types:

- O1. The comments under General, above, apply here.

How the papers may be marked:

- 1. For a few years we had two markers do all the marking and additions independently, followed by comparison of marks in case of any significant discrepancies; however, the small number of discrepancies that arose, the need to coordinate the two markers' policies on partial credit, and logistic difficulties led to the conclusion that a single marker works best, provided there is a second expert to check cases where a main prize is at stake, as well as perhaps also a sample of other cases.
- 2. Draw up and reproduce blank marking sheets (an example may be obtained from me).

3. List the competitors in alphabetical order within groups that allow convenient access later, perhaps U18 boys, U18 girls, U12 boys, U12 girls; check all spelling and birth years. It may be surprising to know that this usually takes about four hours.
4. Check that the name on the paper matches the one on your marking sheet before starting to mark it – clerical errors always have to be carefully guarded against.
5. Start marking slowly. Make notes describing cases suitable for partial credit as they arise, thus providing consistency in the marking. Once the main partial-credit decisions have been made, the marking becomes much easier. Note that an attempt to be generous for partial solutions is not necessarily good, because it is therefore correspondingly ungenerous to those who completed the solution correctly.
6. For the mark written down for any particular task, a sign ‘+’ or ‘-’ may occasionally be added; this indicates later review if that solver turns out to be in the running for a prize, but otherwise the review will not be needed.
7. Even with these facilitations, it usually takes something like 5 minutes per paper, thus 12 papers per hour, and thus at least a whole day. It takes less time for the younger ones who don’t attempt all of the problems, but more time to see what was their intended solution.

Technology:

The following approaches would hardly be feasible at present, but better possibilities might arise in the future. They might help in running solving competitions in other events, which we have occasionally been asked to do.

Answering the questions:

It would be convenient if the questions could be answered by electronic means rather than with pencil and paper. To prevent solvers using solving programs or accessing web sites, one would preferably have a small “dumb” device dedicated just to recording and transmitting the solvers’ keystrokes. It would have to allow them to change their mind for any answer. Whether such a device exists or would be practicable I don’t know.

Marking the answers:

It might be possible to mark the papers at a distance, so that expert markers did not need to travel to the event. Each submitted question sheet could be scanned or photographed and uploaded to the distant expert, maybe via Dropbox. The solver’s name should be on each page, for this purpose. The photographing and uploading process would take quite some time, though, for a volunteer.

How someone may be found to do this:

First, a few comments on the past running of the event. I introduced the event in 2007, with several motivations: (i) I had greatly enjoyed playing in early junior championships and wanted to do something in return; (ii) I had noticed the absence among juniors of the promotion of chess problems and studies, for they had until then been followed mainly by adults, and in fact I did not know of any junior solving event anywhere in the world (that is why I have presumed to give comments above on how such an event may be run) (iii) in recent decades chess-playing has increased hugely among juniors compared to adults in both the level of play and the numbers participating in playing events, and it seemed possible that a similar development favouring juniors would take place in problems and

studies if the juniors were given a chance (iv) I thought that it would be good to increase the presently very small number of local composers of problems and studies, for composing is perhaps the highest art-form in chess, and the first step towards composition is always solving; more direct encouragement of junior composition might eventually be possible too. For some years earlier I had suggested that such a solving event be offered on a “rest” day in the Australian Junior Championships, meeting with universal courteous opposition to the idea. Finally I mentioned it to GM Ian Rogers who was enthusiastically supportive, which eventually led to the first of these events. In that and all the following events Geoff Foster has been an indispensable collaborator.

This has been my main chess project in these years, and I have put a lot of time into it (selection of tasks usually starts about September). If a successor is not in a position to put in the time needed, the event could be simplified in various ways, such as having only direct mates, or only endgame studies, or being only for the older competitors together with a different activity for the younger ones.

The running of a direct-mate solving competition is relatively straightforward. The running of an endgame-study solving competition is much less straightforward. Some studies might be capable of complete computer testing, others not (see earlier). It may not be enough for the person running the event to know the intended solution and the main branch lines and false lines. A solver might put forward a different, unanticipated, analysis of the set position, in which case that analysis has to be evaluated in the limited time available at the event. Probably no human or computer can guarantee perfection in handling all such situations. We naturally do our best, and the studies are a very valuable component of the competition, but it will be healthy to realise that it can only be our best. The selection of studies suitable for our purpose is also not easy and is very time-consuming (see earlier). The point here is that the person running it will need to be as expert as can be managed. Expertise in endgame studies is not widespread, and is perhaps mainly to be found among the top adult players and coaches who, however, would generally not be in a position to take on this job.

I have never sought any kind of personal ownership of the event, and am satisfied to have set it in motion as well as I could. I will also continue so long as that is desired. Geoff Foster has indicated that he is happy to continue as well. When a replacement is needed, the main requirements seem to me to be: (i) a close familiarity with the world of solving direct mates and endgame studies (much closer familiarity than just via local newspapers); (ii) a willingness to spend a lot of time setting and marking the tasks, as well as liaising with the organizers of the main playing event; and (iii) a willingness to travel to the venue. Administrators may ask me for a list of people who may be able to help search for someone suitable to take on this position, whenever it may become vacant.

[End of the Appendix; tables and papers follow.]

Table 1. Number of Competitors, in each Birth-year Group and each Gender

Birth year	2006-2007	2004-2005	2002-2003	2000-2001	1998-1999	1996-1997	Total
Boys	8	17	14	17	12	2	70
Girls	1	1	7	3	1	2	15
Total	9	18	21	20	13	4	85

Table 2. Average Marks/150, in each Birth-year Group and each Gender
(each ten marks represents a problem correctly solved, or corresponding partial credit)

Birth year	2006-2007	2004-2005	2002-2003	2000-2001	1998-1999	1996-1997	All
Boys	26.6	45.0	63.0	77.1	96.3	103.5	64.8
Girls	9.0	11.0	36.4	57.3	89.0	95.5	48.5
All	24.7	43.1	54.1	74.2	95.7	99.5	61.9

**AUSTRALIAN JUNIOR CHESS
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NAME: _____

AGE GROUP (circle): **U8** **U10** **U12** **U14** **U16** **U18**

Year of birth: _____

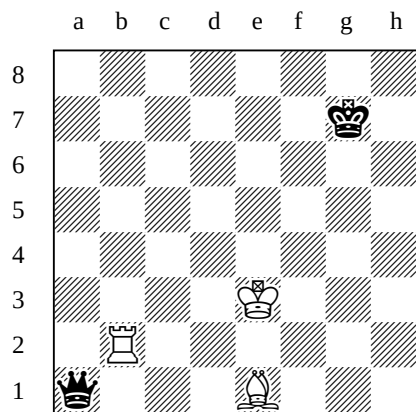
(circle): **BOY** **GIRL**

In all diagrams White is playing up the board. All tasks are worth equal marks. They are ordered according to estimated difficulty, easiest first. It is recommended to start at the beginning and work through in approximate order.

Please write your solution in the space provided near the diagram. For 2-move problems, just give White's first move. For 3-move problems, give up to White's 2nd move. For studies, just go far enough to reach a clearly winning, or drawing, position, without giving minor details.

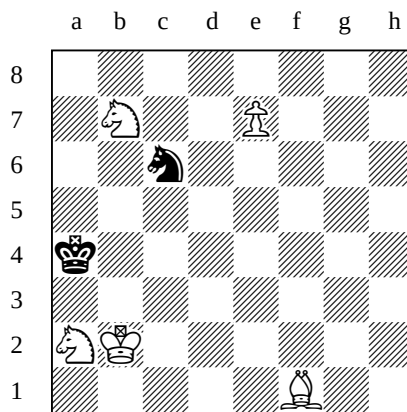
Solve as many tasks as you can, but there is no expectation that you will solve them all! As a guide, those who are young or new to solving might expect to do well on the first page, tasks 1-5; more experienced solvers might do well also on the second page, thus tasks 1-10; experts might also succeed with some on the last page. But there are no restrictions: anyone may attempt any of the tasks, and everyone, including experts, should start at the beginning.

An answer sheet will be available at the end of the solving period.



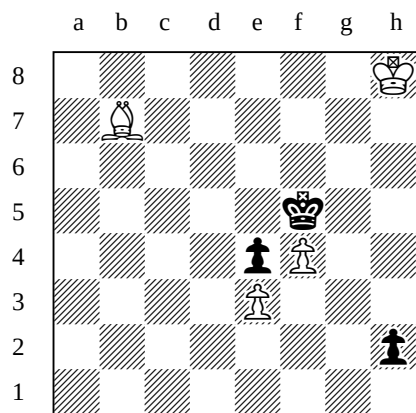
1) White to play and Win

(Note: Give White's first move, and you can then write in words what would follow, up to White's 3rd move.)



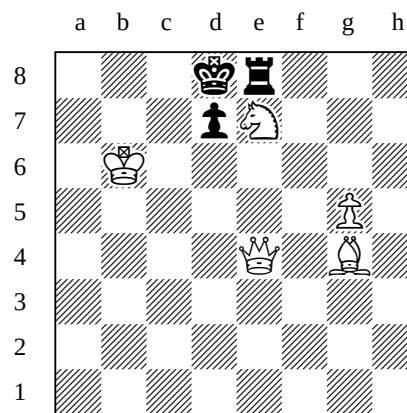
2) White to play and mate in 2 moves

(Hint: Ask yourself why the Pe7 is on the board.)

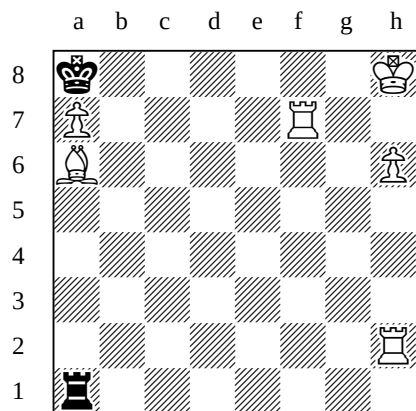


3) White to play and Win

(Note: Give only up to White's 2nd move.)



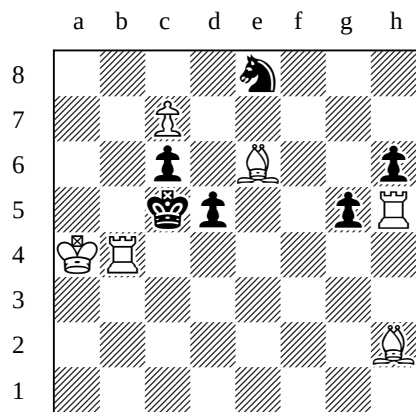
4) White to play and mate in 2 moves



5) White to play and mate in 3 moves

(Note: This is mate in 3 moves, not mate in 2 moves.)

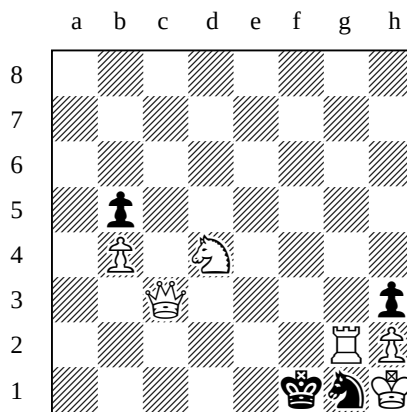
(Hint: 1.Rb2? (threat 2.Rb8#) Rb1! 2.Rxb1 would be stalemate. How can White improve his first move?)



6) White to play and mate in 2 moves

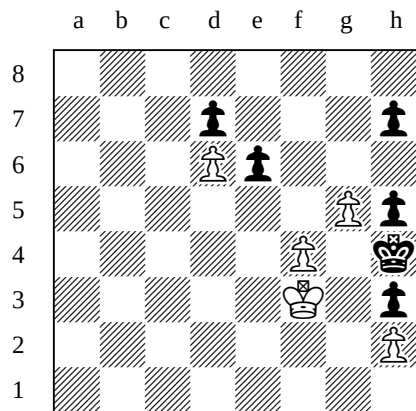
How would Black
answer the try: 1.c8=Q? _____

What is the key? 1. _____

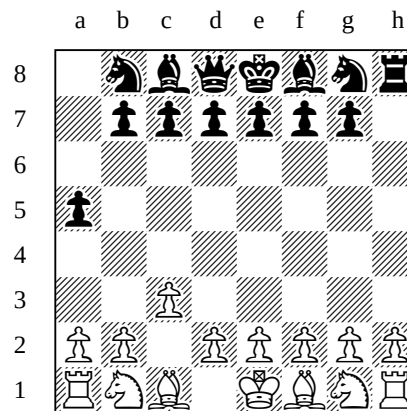


7) Self-mate in 2. White to play and force Black to
give mate on his second move or earlier.

(Note: Black does not want to
give mate, but will have no
choice but to play 2.hxg2.
Give White's first move and his
answer to all Black's defences.)



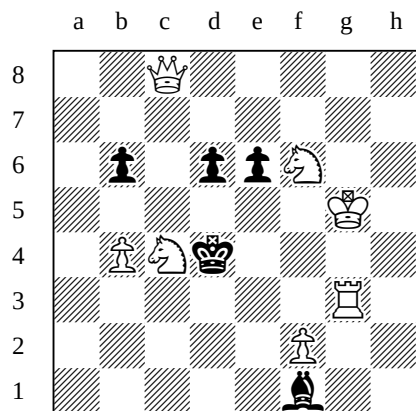
8) White to play and Win



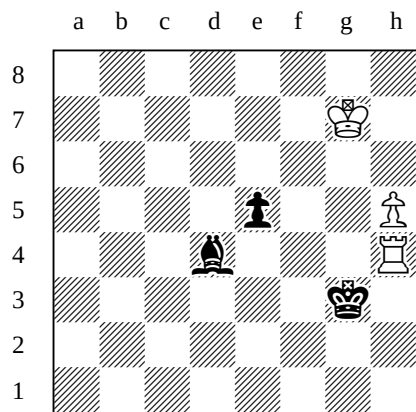
9) Proof game. This position arose after Black's
4th move in a legal (but unusual!) game of chess.
What were the moves?

1. _____ 2. _____

3. _____ 4. _____

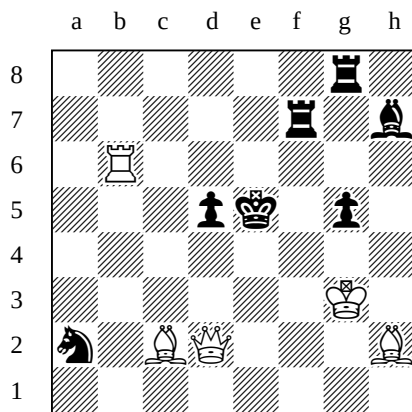


10) White to play and mate in 2 moves

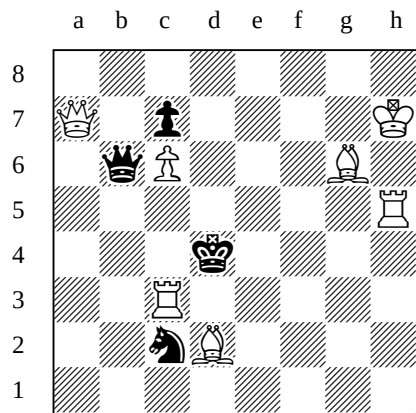


11) White to play and Win

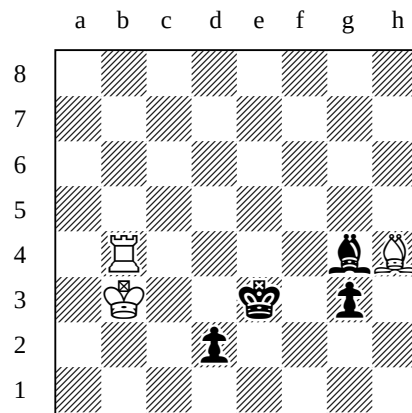
(Note: Assume that the ending K + Q vs K + central P is a win in general.)



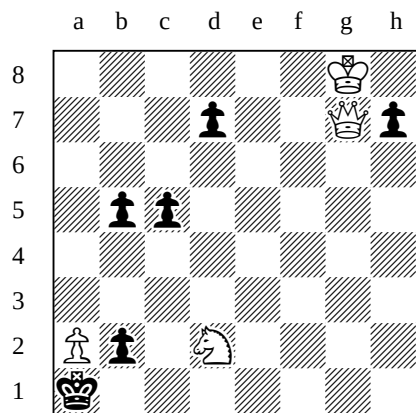
12) White to play and mate in 2 moves



13) White to play and mate in 2 moves



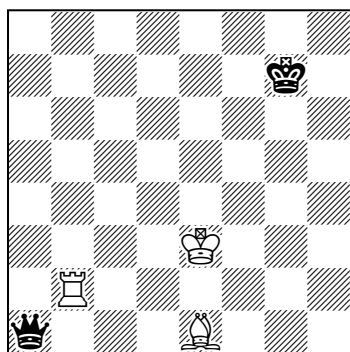
14) White to play and Draw



15) White to play and mate in 3 moves

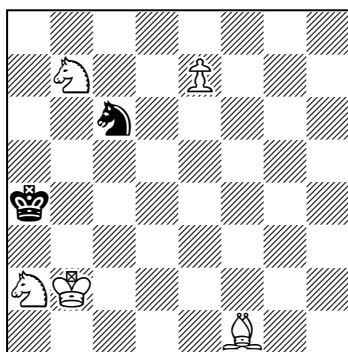
(Note: This is mate in 3 moves, not mate in 2 moves.)

AUSTRALIAN JUNIOR CHESS PROBLEM-SOLVING CHAMPIONSHIP SYDNEY 2014 SOLUTIONS



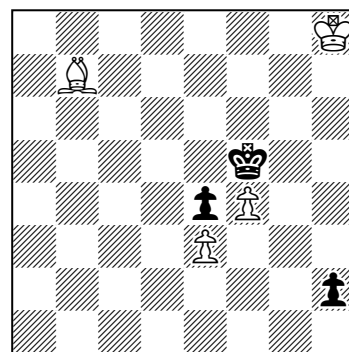
1) Win

1.Bc3+ K any 2.R+ K any
3.BxQ.



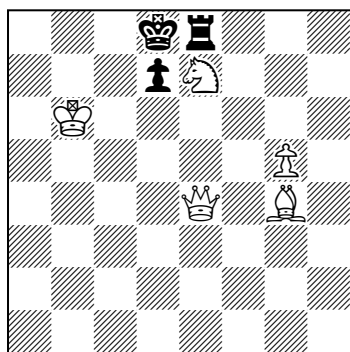
2) Mate in 2

1.e8=Q? stalemate
1.e8=R! (waiting)
1... Na5 2.Nc5; 1... Nb4 2.Nc3;
1... N else 2.Ra8 or Re4.



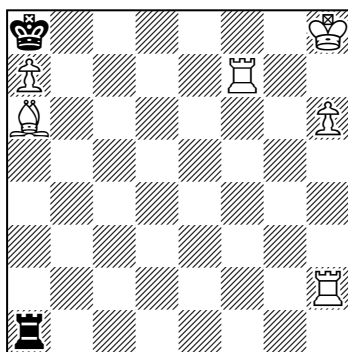
3) Win

1.Kg7 h1=Q 2.Bc8#
(1... other 2.Bxe4)



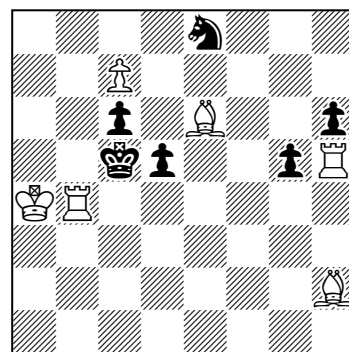
4) Mate in 2

1.Qc6! (threat 2.Qxd7)
1... dxc6 2.Nxc6
1... Kxe7 2.Qf6
1... Rxe7 2.Qa8



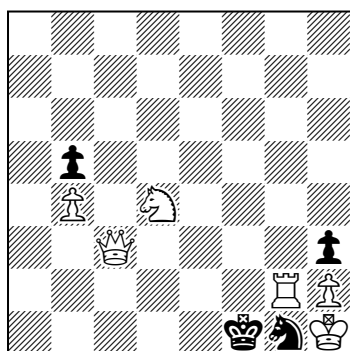
5) Mate in 3

1.Rg2! (threat 2.Rg8#)
1... Rg1 2.Bf1 Rxc2 3.Bxc2.



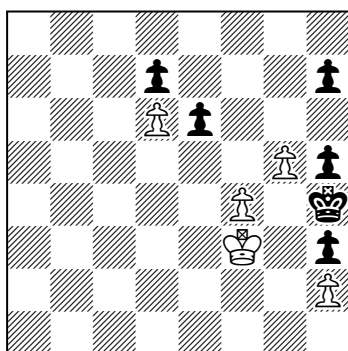
6) Mate in 2

1.c8=Q? (waiting)
1... d4 2.Rb5; 1... g4 2.Rxd5;
1... N~ 2.Qf8; but 1... Nd6!
1.c8=N! (waiting)
1... d4 2.Rc4; 1... g4 2.Bg1;
1... N~ 2.B(x)d6



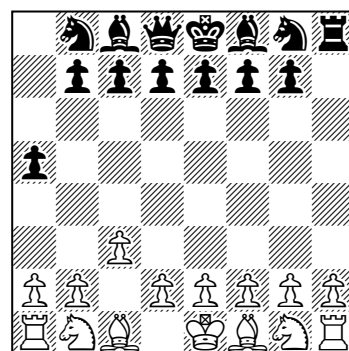
7) Self-mate in 2

1.Nc2 (guarding e1, freeing
the Q to pin the Black N)
1... Ne2 2.Qd3 hxc2
1... Nf3 2.Qf6 hxc2



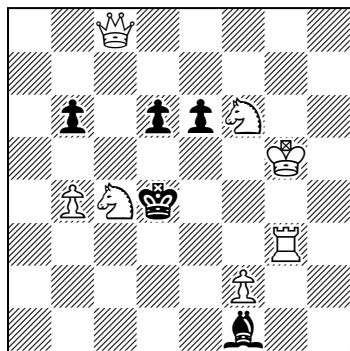
8) Win

1.f5 exf5 2.g6 hxc6 3.Kf4
g5+ 4.Kxf5 g4 5.Kf4 g3
6.hxc3.
(1... Kxc5 2.fxe6)



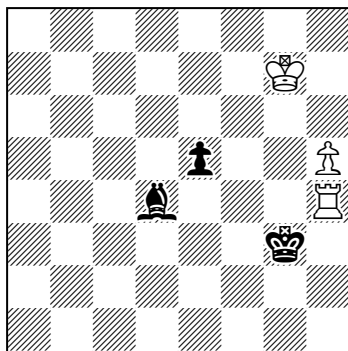
9) Proof game in 4.0 moves

1.c3 a5 2.Qc2 Ra6
3.Qxh7 Rh6 4.Qxh8
Rhx8.



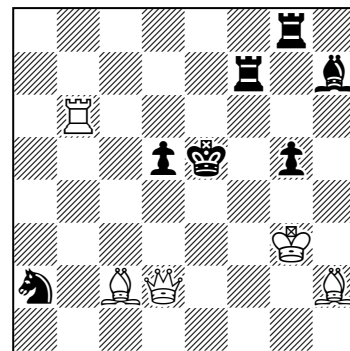
10) Mate in 2

1.Nd2? Bc4!
1.Na5? Bd3!
1.Ne5! (threat 2.Qc3)
1... Bd3 2.Nf3
1... Bc4 2.Nc6
1... Kxe5 2.Qc3



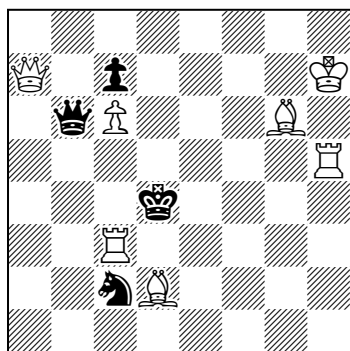
11) Win

1.Re4! (enticing the K to f3,
looking ahead to the 6th move)
Kf3 2.Rxd4 exd4 3.h6 d3
4.h7 d2 5.h8=Q d1=Q
6.Qh5+ (or 5... Ke2 White
wins)



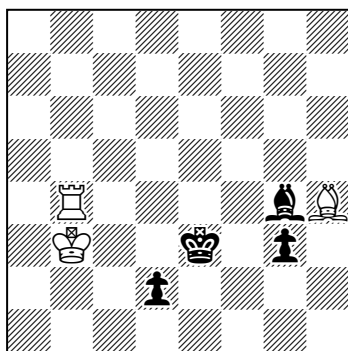
12) Mate in 2

1.Bf5! (threat 2.Kg4)
1... Kxf5 2.Qxd5
1... Rxf5 2.Qe3
1... Bxf5 2.Kf3
1... d4 2.Qa5
1... g4 2.Qf4



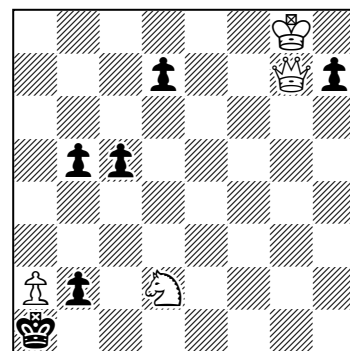
13) Mate in 2

1.Rhc5? (threat 2.R3c4)
1... Qb3,Qb5 2.R(x)b5
1... Qb4 2.Rd3
1... Ne3,Na3 2.B(x)e3
1... Qxc5 2.Qxc5
1... Qa6!
1.Rcc5! (threat 2.Rhd5)
1... Qxc6 2.Rxc6
1... Qb3 2.Rh4
1... Ne3 2.Bc3
1... Nb4 2.Qa1
1... Qxc5 2.Qxc5



14) Draw

1.Bg5+ Kd3! 2.Bxd2!
Bd1+ 3.Ka3 g2 4.Rd4+!
Kxd4 5.Ba5 Kc5 6.Be1
g1=Q 7.Bf2+ Qxf2
stalemate
(or 4... Ke2 5.Be3)



15) Mate in 3

1.Qe5? (threat 2.Qe4) d5!
1.Kxh7? (threat 2.Qg6) d6!
1.Kf8? (waiting) Kxa2!
1.Kh8! (waiting)
1... c4 2.Qg1+ Kxa2 3.Qa7
1... d5,d6 2.Qxh7 Kxa2 3.Qa7
1... h5,h6 2.Qg6 Kxa2 3.Qa6
1... Kxa2 2.Qg8+
1... b4 2.Nc4

Authors

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